

Off the Shelf



Hitman 2: Silent Assassin

Nice shot

There is nothing like a few days, close to God, to get an assassin back into business. *Hitman 2* sees Agent 47, our angel of death, give up cosy living as a gardener in a monastery and retake the streets and a life of crime. A born again.

The game is an immensely satisfying stealth-shooter that eliminates many a problem that plagued the first part. The sequel comes packed with a gorgeous engine, well-designed levels, better AI and controls (although you still cannot jump), and tools aplenty to get your dirty job done. The ingame music merits a special mention—rendered by the Budapest Symphony Orchestra, it integrates with great effect, gelling with both, the locale you are in and the pace of action you are



BATHING WITH THE FISHES: The game has some very interesting, beautifully crafted locales

facing. The gameplay is not all stealth, you can Rambo your way through most of the missions, finishing in minutes what stealth would have required hours to do. The cherry on the pudding lies in sneaking though—guns-a-blazing kills the essence of the title reducing it to an ordinary first-person shooter. Another reason to sneak is the AI: while enemies are morons once you enter a gun fest, they are excellent watchdogs. It is almost as if the action elements were added as an after-thought to the stealth layer to make the game more accessible to casual gamers. Consider this title if stealth gets you high. The action elements might disappoint.

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** Io Interactive ■ **Distributor:** Milestone Interactive Software Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-28381614 ■ **Web site:** www.hitman2.com
Price: Rs 999 ■ **System requirements:** Pentium III 550 MHz or equivalent, 128 MB RAM, 16 MB DirectX 8.1 compatible video card
Rating: ★★★★★



Grand Theft Auto III

Everything mommy wouldn't approve of

Life is a drag. You rob a bank, make a clean getaway and are promptly shot by the hitherto love of your life. Money comes first, honey. Life then reveals its Janus face, arranges an accident and offers a chance to reprieve your days of sin in the big city.

And sinning is such sweet sorrow: break into vehicles, more than 50 of them, ranging from sports cars to ice-cream trucks, from boats to buses. Listen to some 3 hours of great music (from classics to rap; you can even import your own MP3 collection into the game), as you take on the cops, clean out the lesser, wannabe-scum, perform stunts, rob old ladies at gun point and

harass girl scouts. Ok, so no girl-scout-teasing, but you get the drift—if it's naughty and nasty, you can do it. All in a days work.

Grand Theft Auto III is set in Liberty City, a sprawling hive of no-goods that offers a narrative at once both linear and open-ended. Follow the central story to its logical end or shrug it off to take



MEET INTERESTING PEOPLE: and then rearrange their faces

on missions that call on you as a vigilante cop, a fire-fighter, a cab driver, a hit-man or just cruise around for hidden bonuses and packages. The music and voice-acting is top-notch, the AI lets you have a good time and the missions—more than you can shake a very large stick at—are always a blast. If you have nothing better to do for the

next few weeks, pick up this game. Strike that, just pick up this game, life can wait!

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** Rockstar Games ■ **Distributor:** e-xpress Interactive Software Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-28870017 ■ **Web site:** www.rockstargames.com/grandtheftauto3/pc/main.html ■ **Price:** Rs 1,499 ■ **System requirements:** Pentium 450 MHz, 96 MB RAM, 16 MB T&L AGP/PCI video card ■ **Rating:** ★★★★★